

Informed Register

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FRONT PAGE

History of the Self: Dreams

Throughline (NPR)

Our dreams can haunt us. But what are we to make of them? From omens and art to modern science, we tell the story of dreams and the surprising role they may play in our lives. (Originally ran as The Way We Dream)

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FEATURES

Opinion: Why understanding limits is the key to humanity's future

Richard Heinberg · *Ensaia*

Recent news articles about a breakthrough in nuclear fusion research heralded the potential for “limitless” energy. Whenever I read that word limitless I wince. The promise of limitlessness is misleading and sometimes deadly.

Limits exist everywhere in nature. They enable the functioning of systems at scales from the subatomic all the way up to galaxy clusters. If there is any physical thing that could credibly be claimed to be infinite, it is the universe itself. Everything else has boundaries.

Limits and Indigenous Wisdom

Ancient peoples confronted limits every day. In addition to personal limits on strength and endurance, there were also limits to environmental capacity. Overhunt game or overharvest wild plants this season and starvation could follow in the next.

One solution was to move to new habitats. By migrating, people escaped the confines of familiar places, but the benefit was temporary. Human migration altered environments and reduced biodiversity.

However, people who stayed in one place long enough learned the limits to their bioregion's capacity for regeneration. Through a long series of tough lessons, they discovered how many plants of each kind they could harvest and how many of each kind of animal they could hunt. In short, they adopted a worldview and behaviors oriented toward successful adaptation to the finite.

The Restless, Voracious Modern Mind

That changed for some people, starting just a few thousand years ago.

The development of mathematics provided a logical basis for the belief in infinity. It facilitated the expansion of trade. It also helped in the invention and refinement of technologies that assisted in the conquest of Indigenous peoples, allowing conquerors to overleap previous constraints on the scale and wealth of human societies.

At the same time, agriculture enabled population growth, but it gradually robbed soils of nutrients. Sailing ships increased trade but building them led to the deforestation of whole continents. A reckoning with limits seemed to be in store.

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Then a miracle happened: People started using fossil fuels. Coal, oil and natural gas enabled the development of transport technologies that overcame prior limits to travel and trade, so products and resources that were abundant in one place could be transported to places where they were scarce. Fossil fuels could be used to increase the rates of resource extraction. They could be fashioned into plastics and chemicals to substitute for natural materials that were getting scarce. And they could be made into artificial fertilizers to support unsustainable agricultural practices.

All these developments together enabled human numbers to expand from 1 billion to 8 billion in just over two centuries. We were, in effect, stretching existing constraints on population and consumption to the point that it was difficult for many people to see that boundaries still existed at all.

But problems are brewing.

It turns out that fossil fuels suffer from a couple of serious drawbacks: depletion and pollution, including the release of CO₂, which causes climate patterns to become more chaotic and threatens the ecological cycles that support myriads of creatures in addition to us.

The Global Footprint Network currently shows humanity using resources as if we lived on 1.75 Earths — which it is only possible to do by, in effect, robbing future generations.

If the energy-climate conundrum were all we had to worry about, the obvious answer would be to transition industrial society to operate on other, less problematic energy sources. But the energy-climate problem isn't our only survival-level ecological dilemma.

As we've grown our population and consumption, we've been taking habitat away from other organisms. Animal species have suffered average population declines of nearly 70% in the past 52 years and thousands of plant species are endangered as well. Not only that, but we are exhausting the materials that feed the industrial machine. As high-grade ores deplete, miners are forced to dig deeper and process more ore in order to produce the same amounts of copper and other critical materials.

Scientists at the Stockholm Resilience Centre calculated that, of nine critical global ecological thresholds that might lead to collapse, humanity has already crossed six. And the Global Footprint Network currently shows humanity using resources as if we lived on 1.75 Earths — which it is only possible to do by, in effect, robbing future generations.

Altogether, civilization's survival dilemma in the 21st century is best described by a concept from population ecology — overshoot. This refers to the situation where a crucial resource temporarily becomes more abundant, thereby enabling a group of organisms to grow its population beyond levels that can be sustained over the long run. Temporary energy abundance has led to more food, more people, more commercial products, more knowledge, more comfort and more convenience. But we are about to become victims of

6 Signs Your Skin Needs Medical Attention, Stat

Greatist

These symptoms may signal an underlying condition and the need to see a dermatologist.

Your skin is your most visible organ, so it's easy to notice when something seems off. It's normal to experience some skin issues from time to time, like itchiness, breakouts, or ingrown hairs. But when these skin symptoms stick around, it could be a sign that something more serious is going on.

Many of these skin issues get better with the right at-home remedies or changes in your skin care routine. For example, if dryness pops up when Old Man Winter comes along, slathering on a more intense moisturizer may help.

But if skin symptoms don't go away with a little self-care — or they return frequently — a chronic skin condition might be the culprit. However, just because you have a lasting symptom or two doesn't necessarily mean you have a chronic health issue.

Here are the symptoms you should watch for and what they might mean. And if they don't improve, consider checking in with a dermatologist for a proper diagnosis and a plan of action.

If you wish you had cat claws to satisfy your skin itch, you could be dealing with eczema. Eczema is an umbrella term for several conditions that impact the skin, with atopic dermatitis being the most common.

With most forms of eczema, your skin may show signs of inflammation, such as:

itchiness

red, gray, brown, or purple skin

a rash

intense dryness

These symptoms may flare up occasionally and then go into periods of remission, where your skin isn't as irritated.

Allergies can also lead to itchiness. For example, if you're allergic to a skin care ingredient, a fabric type, a pet, or another allergen, your skin might react as a way to tell you to avoid this trigger.

Ongoing or regular periods of itchiness are a reason to see a dermatologist.

A rash can affect the skin in various ways, including:

red, gray, brown, or purple patches

itchiness

raised bumps

hives (urticaria)

A one-off or temporary rash might result from friction or chafing from a new outfit item. It could also be a heat rash when sweat gets trapped in skinfolds or bodily creases.

A persistent rash could be a sign of eczema or allergies. However, different types of rashes can be a sign of other things. For example, a butterfly-shaped (malar) rash across the face is a common sign of an autoimmune disease known as lupus.

If you frequently experience skin rashes, talk with a dermatologist to help you get to the bottom of the issue.

Dryness, cracking, or scaling

Dry skin can be just that — dry skin. Common causes include:

cold weather

dry weather

dry indoor heat

super-hot baths or showers

bathing too frequently

chlorine exposure from swimming

irritation from ingredients in skin care or soaps

sun exposure

But if your skin is so dry it makes you want to bathe in a vat of thick moisturizer, it could be a sign of psoriasis.

Psoriasis is an inflammatory skin condition potentially caused by an overactive immune system. It can lead to dry, cracked, or scaling skin. In fact, psoriasis often involves a buildup of scales or plaques on areas like the elbows or knees — though they can occur anywhere.

Psoriasis and eczema are different conditions, but they have overlapping symptoms that mimic each other. So if you experience these symptoms, it's important to see a dermatologist to identify and treat the underlying cause.

Changes in skin color — including red, brown, gray, or purple patches of skin — can be a sign of various skin issues, including eczema, psoriasis, or allergies. But it can also be a sign of rosacea.

Rosacea typically involves persistent redness that looks like a sunburn or blushing. It may also lead to skin thickening.

The good news? Rosacea is highly treatable. So working with a dermatologist can help you address it.

Acne, cysts, or bumps

A persistent rash could be a sign of eczema or allergies.

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What Is Looksmaxxing? How the Viral Trend Promotes Toxic Beauty Standards for Young Men

Healthline

Appearance-based social media trends like looksmaxxing, softmaxxing, and hardmaxxing are often framed as self-improvement, but experts say they can contribute to body dysmorphia, anxiety, and even self-harm—especially for young men. Edu Bastidas + David Garcia/Stocksy

Looksmaxxing, a social media-driven trend encouraging men to aggressively “optimize” their appearance, is gaining popularity.

It’s related to similar appearance-based trends, like softmaxxing and hardmaxxing.

While often framed as self-improvement, experts warn these trends can fuel body dysmorphia, anxiety, eating disorders, and even self-harm.

Young men may be particularly vulnerable due to several factors, including online messaging about masculinity and worth.

A growing trend on social media is encouraging young men to “maximize” their appearance.

Known as looksmaxxing, the trend focuses on pursuing the “ideal” face and body. It follows similar social media trends, known as softmaxxing and hardmaxxing, which encourage everything from intensive grooming routines to cosmetic procedures and extreme body modification.

While proponents say these practices can be empowering, mental health experts warn they can fuel body dysmorphia, anxiety, and other unhealthy behaviors.

Jason Fierstein, MA, LPC, founder of Phoenix Men’s Counseling, said these trends are toxic and harmful.

“Young men fall into this false sense of acceptance, and what they believe women want from them,” he told Healthline. “They can get caught up in potentially lifelong struggles with feeling inadequate and handling that inadequacy.”

He further described looksmaxxing as a “social media-driven body dysmorphia trend.”

“People will focus their energies on improving their physique based on feelings of inferiority or inadequacy,” Fierstein said.

“Men can get caught in a cycle of trying to ‘optimize’ their looks, but as mental health clinicians, we know that if you’re feeling inadequate or inferior, those are the issues to work on with a qualified therapist.”

What are the differences between the looksmaxxing, softmaxxing, and hardmaxxing trends?

While the terminology differs, the trends all have one thing in common: the desire to obsessively change one’s appearance.

“Looksmaxxing is essentially self-improvement put on overdrive. It’s reframing the male physique as something to be engineered,” Fierstein explained.

While softmaxxing involves subtler changes to one’s appearance, often achieved through grooming and lifestyle adjustments, hardmaxxing is more extreme.

“It involves serious methods to change your looks, such as nose jobs, Botox, hair transplants, and chin surgery. The obvious issue with this is that once you open that Pandora’s Box, it’s hard to close the lid,” Fierstein noted.

Christine Ruberti-Bruning, MA, ATR-BC, CEDS, LPC, licensed therapist and certified eating disorder specialist, summed up the differences.

“There’s nothing wrong with wanting to look good, and caring for your appearance can build confidence and be gender affirming. But the big difference is that looksmaxxing is rooted in self-hate and trying to fit in, at the cost of your health and safety,” she pointed out.

“Hardmaxxing, meanwhile, seems to be dipping its toe into self-harm territory, especially some of its associated trends, like smashing your face with a hammer.”

Why looksmaxxing is particularly popular among young men

Why does looksmaxxing seem to be resonating with young men in particular?

Fierstein said young men, especially teens, are typically at a stage of their lives when they are still figuring out who they are, and many may be searching for ways to project what they perceive as “the ‘correct’ version of masculinity.”

Fierstein believes trends like looksmaxxing may be related to incel culture and the manosphere, too.

“It started several years ago, with male gurus like Jordan Peterson, Joe Rogan, and the Tate brothers. These types of ‘masculine’ influencers led men astray,” he said.

Ruberti-Bruning shared another perspective about potential contributing factors.

“Mental health issues and loneliness are also prevalent right now, making young men especially vulnerable,” she noted.

The line between healthy self-improvement and unhealthy behaviors

Why Does My Side Hurt When I Run? Causes and Prevention Tips

Greatist

Experts don't know for sure but think side cramps during exercise may be caused by diaphragm issues, poor posture, or nerve irritation from your foot striking the ground.

Side stitch, stomach cramp, side ache — whatever you wanna call it, that mid-run pain in your tum can seriously *cramp* your runner's high.

This pesky prob that plagues runners and athletes all over has a scientific name: Exercise-related transient abdominal pain (ETAP) . Though experts don't know exactly what causes it, they have some ideas and tips about how to stop it.

Before you double-over during your next marathon , here's what to know.

KarraStock/Getty Images

What is a side stitch?

That fateful stab in your side is most likely to happen during exercise where your upper bod says tight and upright for an extended period, such as when you run , jog, bike, hike, play soccer, etc.

This common prob has been around for ages — the first historical mention is from ancient Roman philosopher Pliny the Elder . Yet, scientists still haven't reached a consensus on its exact cause. We know that it affects up to 70% of runners each year.

It's also more likely to occur on the right side.

What causes a side stitch?

A stiff spine or poor posture (according to older research from 2010) could contribute to side stitches – but TBH, the pros don't know for sure.

According to a 2022 review , researchers also think a side stitch might be caused by your right foot hitting the ground while you breathe out, irritating a phrenic nerve. Researchers think this, in turn, may bother the lining of your abdomen (particularly on the lower right side). Since most people are right-foot dominant, this is one possible explanation.

Experts also theorize that it could be triggered by the boost of blood flow around the diaphragm when running .

Furthermore, fueling up before a big race is excellent — but eating or drinking large quantities right before running may boost your risk of getting a side stitch, anecdotal reports suggest.

How to treat a side stitch

When a side stitch strikes, don't stress – there are steps you can take, including:

Slowing down , which should help lend some immediate relief. When the pain subsides, you can slowly build your pace back up.

Stretch it out by raising your arms overhead, leaning to the opposite side of the pain, and breathing deeply. That may open up your abdomen and offer some relief.

Apply gentle pressure by pressing your palm into the cramp while breathing deeply.

How to prevent a side stitch

To stop a side stitch before it begins, here are some ideas FTW:

Practice mindful workout breathing. According to a 2022 review , slower breathing during exercise might “trick” your bod into thinking the exercise is easier, increasing pleasant feelings and reducing stress. While the study doesn't mention side cramps, it could be worth a try since stitches may be linked to blood flow surrounding the diaphragm.

Avoid big meals or beverages a couple of hours before you run. Though experts don't know for sure, too much food or liquid in your belly could potentially put extra pressure on your precious organs, leading to a cramp.

Work on your posture . Proper posture can improve breath flow and running performance. Research from 2014 suggests building up your abs could help prevent side stitches.

Stay hydrated to stay healthy in general and potentially prevent side stitches.

Start slow and work your way up. When working out, starting small and gradually upping your challenge helps reduce the risk of injury. In the same way, gradually increasing your speed rather than diving straight into a sprint may also help reduce the risk of a side stitch.

When to see a doctor

Side stitches are usually harmless. But it's always a good idea to visit a pro if you experience any of the following probs:

Pain under your breastbone (higher upper than a side stitch) accompanied by difficulty catching your breath could indicate a heart or lung issue.

Persistent pain after running could indicate a chronic condition.

Severe or debilitating stomach pain or cramps could also signal a more serious condition.

Side stitches are a common issue and not typically the reason for concern. Though pros don't know what causes them, they think issues with breathing, posture, or nerves may play a role.

How to prevent a side stitch To stop a side stitch before it begins, here are some ideas FTW: Practice mindful workout breathing.

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Text Neck Exercises: Simple Moves to Ease Digital Strain

Greatist

Some gentle stretches and changes to your device habits can help alleviate neck pain.

Whether you're caught up in doomscrolling or just checking your work emails, chances are you're spending a lot of time on your phone. But all that screen time can lead to a pesky condition called "text neck." Hunching over your device can leave you with some severe aches and pains.

So, hold your phone up to eye level and check out these easy tips to get rid of text neck fast!

AleksandarNakic/Getty Images

What is text neck?

Also known as "tech neck," text neck is a term coined by a chiropractor to describe the neck pain you might feel after spending too much time looking down at your phone.

Most of us check our phones with our heads tilted forward and down. When you do this for too long, the muscles in your neck get strained. The muscles in the back are over-stretched, while the ones in the front are compressed.

Text neck symptoms

If you have text neck, here's what you might be dealing with:

Stiffness and difficulty moving your neck

Dull aching or sharp, stabbing pain

Pain that radiates into your shoulders and arms

Weak shoulder muscles

Tension headaches from tight neck muscles

But don't get bent out of shape about overusing your favorite device. There's no solid proof that your phone habits are to blame for your neck woes. Several studies found no connection between using your device and having neck or shoulder pain.

You could get a sore neck from overusing your muscles for many other reasons, like genetic factors, weight issues, or bad posture. "Text neck" might be a term concocted by a chiropractor to get your business. But, hey, we're not judging.

Exercises for text neck

To help ease text neck pain, try these simple exercises.

Neck circles

While sitting, slowly rotate your head 360 degrees.

Let your jaw slack as you roll backward, and be very gentle.

Rotate your head clockwise five times, then counterclockwise five times.

Again, go VERY slowly (like a full ten seconds for one rotation), and don't force anything!

Side neck stretch

Take your right hand and reach over your head to the top of your left ear.

Use the weight of your arm to guide your head toward your right shoulder very slowly. (Don't engage your neck muscles at all!)

Remember to breathe deeply, even if your armpits are ripe.

When you feel discomfort, pause and breathe again, letting your head stay there for three full breaths.

Gently remove your hand from your head and use it to push your head slowly back up to an upright position.

Repeat on the left side.

Shoulder rolls

Slowly raise your shoulders.

Without stopping, roll them back and down.

Do 10 to 15 reps.

Repeat the exercise, but roll your shoulders forward and down this time.

Bonus: Rolling your shoulders will help with your dance moves and text neck.

Chin tucks

Gently tuck your chin towards your chest, like you're making a super sexy double chin. Bonus: Smile like Kristen Wiig while doing this part.

Keep your head level — no tilting or bending!

Hold that position for 5 seconds (or the length of a deep breath if counting isn't your thing).

Relax your neck and repeat.

Tech neck treatments

Aside from these cubicle-friendly exercises, here are some ideas to help keep text neck from being a regular pain in the y'know:

Hold your phone, tablet, or device a bit higher to reduce your head and neck stress.

When Things Fall Apart (Throwback)

Throughline (NPR)

Climate change, political unrest, random violence: modern society can often feel like what the filmmaker Werner Herzog calls “a thin layer of ice on top of an ocean of chaos and darkness.” In the United States, polls indicate that many people believe law and order is the only thing protecting us from the savagery of our neighbors. This idea is often called “veneer theory.” But is it true?

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We The People: Free Speech

Throughline (NPR)

The First Amendment. Book bans, disinformation, the wild world of the internet. Free speech debates are all around us. What were the Founding Fathers thinking when they created the First Amendment, and how have the words they wrote in the 18th century been stretched and shaped to fit a world they never could have imagined? It’s a story that travels through world wars and culture wars. Through the highest courts and the Ku Klux Klan. Today on Throughline’s We the People : What exactly is free speech, and how has the answer to that question changed in the history of the U. S.? (Originally ran as The Freedom of Speech)

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IN BRIEF

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): Captain America: an all-American superhero. Clad in red, white, and blue, he carries only a shield. And he fights only when he must. When it’s right.

But what happens when what’s right isn’t so clear? And how does a comic book hero designed to represent America’s values survive in a changing world?

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Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): The Fifth Amendment. You have the right to remain silent when you’re being questioned in police custody, thanks to the Fifth’s protection against self-incrimination. But most people end up talking to police anyway. Why? Today on Throughline’s We the People: the Fifth Amendment, the right to remain silent, and how hard it can be to use it.

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The Creeping Coup

Throughline (NPR)

History of the Self: Aging

Throughline (NPR)

On the surface, the story of Sudan's war is about two generals vying for power. But it's also about a vast web of international interests involving the U. S., China, Russia, and the UAE. Today on the show, the story of how things in Sudan got to this point, and the effects of the conflict around the world. This episode originally ran in 2024 and has been updated.

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Defeating old age? In 1899, Elie Metchnikoff woke up in Paris to learn he had done just that. At least, that's what the newspaper headlines said. Before long he was inundated with mail from people begging him to help them live forever. The only problem? He didn't know how to do it.

At the time, Metchnikoff was one of the world's most famous scientists. And he believed aging was a disease he could cure. He dedicated his life to that quest, spending his days interviewing centenarians, pulling gray hair out of colleagues and old dogs, and boiling strawberries — all in the pursuit of eternal youth. If you've ever had yogurt for breakfast, you likely have Metchnikoff to thank. (This episode first ran as *The Man Who Cured Aging*)

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A History of Zionism

Throughline (NPR)

Since October 7th, the term Zionism has been everywhere in the news. It's been used to support Israel in what it calls its war against Hamas: a refrain to remind everyone why Israel exists and why it must be protected. Others have used Zionism to describe what they view as Israel's collective punishment of civilians in Gaza, and its appropriation of Palestinian territories — what they often call “settler colonialism.” Zionism has been defined and redefined again and again, and the definitions are often built on competing historical interpretations. So unsurprisingly, we've received many requests from you, our audience, to explore the origins of Zionism. On today's episode, we go back to the late 19th century to meet the people who organized the modern Zionist movement.

Correction: An earlier version of this episode incorrectly described Ze'ev Jabotinsky as a right-wing settler who helped form the paramilitary organization the Irgun. Jabotinsky was a conservative Zionist thinker whose ideas influenced some of the founders of the Irgun. While Jabotinsky did advocate Jewish settlement in Palestine, he himself lived mostly in Europe and died before Israel's founding.

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The Whiteness Myth (Throwback)

Throughline (NPR)

In 1923, an Indian American man named Bhagat Singh Thind told the U.S. Supreme Court that he was white, and therefore eligible to become a naturalized citizen. He based his claim on the fact that he was a member of India's highest caste and identified as an Aryan. His claims were supported by the so-called Indo-European language theory, a controversial idea at the time that says nearly half the world's population speak a language that originated in one place. Theories about who lived in that place inspired a racist ideology that contended that the original speakers of the language were a white supreme race that colonized Europe and Asia thousands of years ago. This was used by many to define whiteness and eventually led to one of the most horrific events in history. On this episode of Throughline, we unpack the myths around this powerful idea and explore the politics and promise of the mother tongue.

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All Wars Are Fought Twice (2022)

Throughline (NPR)

“All wars are fought twice, the first time on the battlefield, the second time in memory,” writes Pulitzer Prize-winning author Viet Thanh Nguyen. This week on Throughline, we want to pause the news cycle to think about not just how war is experienced or consumed, but how it’s remembered. A refugee from the Vietnam War, Nguyen calls himself a scholar of memory — someone who studies how we remember events of the past, both as people and as nations. As the war in Ukraine continues and conflicts around the globe displace millions, we speak with Nguyen about national memory, selective forgetting, and the refugee stories that might ultimately help us move forward.

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What Happened After Civilization Collapsed

Throughline (NPR)

What happens after everything falls apart? The end of the Bronze Age was a moment when an entire network of ancient civilizations collapsed, leaving behind only clues to what happened. Today, scholars have pieced together a story where everything from climate change to mass migration to natural disasters played a role. What the end of the Bronze Age can teach us about avoiding catastrophe and what comes after collapse.

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The Scent of History

Throughline (NPR)

What if we told you that the key to time travel has been right in front of our eyes this whole time? Well, it has: it’s in our noses. Today on the show, the science — and politics — of smell, and how it links our past and our present.

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